

A Night Off — Arcade Game 6 Design Document

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Overview

A Night Off is a 1–6 player third-person 3D comedy sandbox set in a dockside bar called the Sodden Gull. The crew of the Nautilus have one night ashore. They drink, flirt, play darts and pool and poker, lie to each other at the bullshit table, get their fortunes told, start fights or avoid them, and try to make it to the morning with their money, their dignity, and both kidneys. Nothing in it is serious; everything in it has consequences, and the consequences are the jokes.

Design pillars

1. **A night is a story you tell afterward.** The game's goal is the story at breakfast: who went home with the fortune teller, who lost a kidney, who won the bar in a poker hand, who got arrested. The morning-after screen is the real scoreboard.
2. **Drinking is the dial.** Every drink trades charisma for toughness. Sober, you talk your way through the night; drunk, you fight your way through it; too drunk, you lose your night to a blackout and someone else narrates it.
3. **The bar is alive and it changes.** Patrons come and go, the crowd swells and thins, events walk in the door, and the room itself gets messier, louder, and stranger as the hours pass.
4. **Everyone has a personality and a memory.** Thirty regulars with traits, moods, and grudges that last the night and, for some, across nights.
5. **Silly with friends.** Mechanics are simple to pick up, deep enough to scheme with, and built for six people shouting at each other.

Tone. Brass-and-gaslight dockside, the same inked style as Depth, played for laughs: a drunk Mechanic trying to line up a dart, a Siren reading tarot in the corner, a biker gang that turns out to be a book club. Violence is cartoon bar-brawl: black eyes, broken bottles, people thrown over tables and waking up in the alley. Romance is flirting, a walk out the door, and a fade to black with a morning-after line. The kidney thing is a comedy consequence, not horror: you wake in a bathtub of ice with a note and a stitch, and for the rest of the game you get drunk twice as fast.

Session. One night, 25–40 minutes real time, on a clock from 7 p.m. to 3 a.m. (or until every player is asleep, arrested, hospitalized, or gone home). Players can leave early, which ends their night and starts their morning.

Relationship to the other arcade games. It reuses Red Tide's 3D renderer, inked low-poly style, rig and Chain animation, and the shared networking layer, plus Flats' card and physics code for the poker and bullshit tables and Scuttle's bot seats. It does not share any design with them: it's a social sandbox, not a shooter.

The night

A night runs on a clock from 7 p.m. to 3 a.m. at about four real minutes per game hour. The clock drives the crowd, the events, the prices, and the patrons' moods, so the same bar is a different place at 8, at midnight, and at 2.

Hour	Crowd	What tends to happen
7–8 p.m.	Quiet: 4–8 regulars, the bartender, the fortune teller setting up	Cheap drinks, easy conversation, the pool table free, the best time to win money at darts
8–10 p.m.	Filling: 10–18 patrons	First event rolls; poker starts when four sit; the band (if any) plays
10 p.m.–12 a.m.	Peak: 18–30 patrons, standing room	Second event; fights start; flirting is easiest (everyone's charisma threshold drops as the room drinks)
12–1 a.m.	Loud and loose: 15–25	Last big event; the bartender starts cutting people off; patrons begin leaving in pairs
1–2 a.m.	Thinning: 6–12	Last call at 1:30; prices double; the kidney thieves' window opens
2–3 a.m.	Dregs: 2–6	The bartender wants you gone; the mini golf course lights go off; anyone still here is a story

Busy and quiet nights. The host rolls a crowd curve at the start: Dead (half the numbers above), Normal, Packed (1.5×, standing room all night), or Random (it changes hour to hour, and nobody tells you). A dead night is for conversations and pool; a packed night is for

fights and poker.

How a player's night ends

Ending	How	What the morning says
Walked home	Leave through the front door any time	The safe ending; the score is whatever you kept
Went home with someone	Flirting succeeded and you took the offer	A fade to black and a morning line that depends on who; see Flirting
Passed out	Drunk meter hit 100	You wake on the floor, the alley, or a stranger's porch, minus some money; a teammate can carry you out instead
Knocked out	Lost a brawl	Same as passed out, plus a black eye for the next night
Arrested	The police inspection went badly	Night over, 200 fine, a mugshot on the morning screen
Hospitalized	A real injury (stabbed, shot, hit by the biker's bike)	Night over, hospital bill, a scar
Robbed and dumped	The kidney thieves, the cartel, or a mugging in the alley	You keep playing; you've lost money, an item, or an organ
Thrown out	The bartender barred you	Night over on the pavement with your tab unpaid

The night ends for everyone at 3 a.m. or when the last player's night ends.

The morning after

Every player gets a morning screen: where they woke up, what they have, what they lost, who they went home with, and a one-line newspaper headline about the night ("SIX SAILORS, ONE KIDNEY, A TRIUMPHANT GOAT"). Then the scoreboard:

Score	Points
Money kept over what you walked in with	1 per 10
Games won (darts, pool, golf, poker, bullshit)	20 each
Fights won	30 each; 60 for a win while sober
Went home with someone	100 (50 if it went badly)
Survived an event (police, robbery, cartel) with money and organs	50 each
Stories (achievements: a hole-in-one, a bluff that cleaned the table, winning a fight with a fish)	25 each
Still have both kidneys	50
Walked home sober	40 (the hard way)

Arcade tokens pay out on score; the headline and the morning line are the real reward.

The bar: the Sodden Gull

A two-storey dockside pub with a yard, built so that every room has a reason to go there and every room can go wrong. The whole place is about 40 m by 30 m plus the yard; it's one continuous space with no loading.

Room	What's there	What can happen
The front door and coat rack	The bouncer (off duty until events), the chalkboard of tonight's prices, the exit	Leaving; being thrown out; events arrive here
The main bar	A long brass counter, the bartender, 20 stools, the till, the bartender's shotgun under the counter, the tab book	Drinks, conversation with the bartender, getting behind the counter (see Weapons), last call
The snug	A small side room with a fireplace, two armchairs, the fortune teller's table	Fortunes, quiet conversations, the best flirting spot

Room	What's there	What can happen
The games room	Two pool tables, the dartboard with a chalk scoreboard, three slot machines, the scratch-off dispenser	Pool, darts, slots, scratch-offs, cue-and-bottle fights
The card room	A poker table (6 seats), the bullshit table (6 seats), a cigar cabinet	Poker, bullshit, side bets, cheating and being caught cheating
The dance floor and stage	A small stage, a piano, a jukebox, space for a band or a brawl	Dancing (a rhythm mini-game that raises charisma for 5 minutes), the band, the bachelorette party, the big fights
The toilets	Two stalls, a sink, a mirror that shows your drunk face, a window to the alley	Sobering up (water: -5 drunk), the kidney thieves' preferred exit, hiding from the police
The kitchen	A fryer, a cook who hates everyone, the back door	Food (sobers you), a frying pan (a weapon), the back door to the alley
Upstairs rooms	Four rooms rented by the hour, a landing with a view of the bar	Where "going home with someone" sometimes happens without going home; the robbery's safe is up here
The yard	A nine-hole mini golf course under string lights, benches, a smokers' corner, the bike rack	Mini golf, smokers' conversations, where the biker gang parks, where the cartel does business
The alley	Bins, a fence, the toilet window, a sleeping dog	Where you wake up; where muggings happen; where the dog becomes your friend if fed

The developing environment

The room changes with the clock and with what the players do, and the state persists for the whole night:

- **Mess.** Every drink leaves a glass; every fight leaves broken furniture; by 1 a.m. a busy night is a floor of glass and overturned chairs the cook sweeps grudgingly. Broken bottles on the floor are weapons for anyone who picks them up.
- **Light and sound.** The lamps dim as the night goes on; the jukebox gets louder; after midnight someone always puts on the same sad song, and the bar sings it.
- **Damage.** Smashed windows stay smashed; a broken pool cue means one less cue; if the piano is thrown through the window during the biker gang event, there's no piano. The bartender's mood tracks the damage and his prices follow it.
- **Weather.** Rain starts at a random hour; the yard clears, the golf balls float, and the smokers come inside.
- **The dog.** The alley dog can be fed, befriended, brought inside, and will fight for whoever feeds it most. It is the single most effective ally in the game.
- **Persistence across nights (optional profile).** The bartender remembers a player who paid their tab, a player who didn't, and a player who shot his window. The regulars remember who fought them. It's a short memory (three nights) and always reset by buying a round.

Drinking

Every player has a **drunk meter** from 0 to 100. Drinks raise it, time and food lower it, and every number in the game reads it. The trade is always the same: charisma down, toughness up.

The meter

Drunk	State	Charisma	Toughness	What it looks like
0–19	Sober	100%	100%	Steady camera, clean aim, normal walk
20–39	Merry	110% (the only bonus: a little courage)	110%	Slight sway, warmer dialogue options appear
40–59	Drunk	80%	130%	Camera lag, aim drift in games, slurred captions, walking curves

Drunk	State	Charisma	Toughness	What it looks like
60–79	Hammered	50%	160%	Double vision in menus, the wrong dialogue option sometimes fires, stumbles into tables, insults are the only flirting left
80–99	Wrecked	20%	200%	Fights don't hurt (damage taken –50%), can't play games well, throws up (a 5 s stun that lowers the meter by 15), says things
100	Blackout	—	—	Passed out: a teammate carries you, or the night narrates what you did for the next 10 minutes (random, usually expensive) and you wake somewhere

Charisma is the roll bonus in every conversation and flirt. **Toughness** is damage dealt and HP in fights. The curve is the game's thesis: the best fighter in the bar can't talk to anyone, and the smoothest talker can't take a punch.

The drinks (the bartender's menu)

Drink	Drunk	Price (7 p.m.)	Side effect
Water	–5	Free	The bartender judges you
Small beer	+8	3	None
Pint	+12	5	None
Rum	+20	8	+5% charisma for 2 minutes (sea-legs confidence)
Whisky	+22	10	+10% toughness for 2 minutes
Gin	+18	8	Captions get honest: your dialogue options show what they'll really sound like

Drink	Drunk	Price (7 p.m.)	Side effect
The Gull (house special)	+35	15	Random: one of the above effects doubled, or a hiccup that ruins your next dart
Absinthe	+45	25	The fortune teller's visions become visible to you for 5 minutes (you see patrons' trait icons)
Grog (crew's choice)	+15	6	Nautilus crew only; +10% charisma with other crew
Coffee	-10	4	Hands shake for 1 minute (aim -10%)
Chips	-8	4	From the kitchen; eating takes 10 s
The cook's stew	-20	9	Eating takes 30 s; a 10% chance the cook spits in it (+5 drunk instead)

Time lowers the meter by 1 per game minute (about 15 per real minute). Prices rise 20% at 10 p.m. and double at last call. Rounds (buying for everyone within 5 m) cost the sum but add +10 charisma with each recipient for 10 minutes.

Hangovers and the next night

If the profile persists, a night that ended above 60 drunk gives the next night a hangover: start at -10% charisma for the first game hour and a sensitivity to the jukebox.

The kidney

If a player wakes without a kidney (see Flirting, the Cartel, the Robbery), every drink's drunk value is doubled for the rest of the night and, with a persistent profile, for two nights after. The morning screen shows the stitch. There is exactly one way to get a kidney back: win one in the poker game's high-stakes pot, which the cartel sometimes puts up. Doing so is worth 200 score and a headline.

Patrons: the personality system

Every patron is built from the same parts: a **type** (what they're doing here), three **traits** from a shared list, a **mood** that moves during the night, a **tolerance** for being bothered, a **secret** (what happens if you get close), and a **memory** of what each player has done to

them. Thirty regulars are hand-written; on busy nights the generator fills the rest from the same parts with random names and looks.

Types

Type	What they want	How to approach	Danger
Talker	To tell you about their life	Ask questions; buy a drink; listen (a conversation mini-game)	Boring you into drinking faster: every minute listening is +2 drunk if you keep nodding
Flirt	Company	See Flirting	Some of them are the kidney thieves
Brooder	To be left alone	Don't; or buy one drink and say nothing	Antagonized, they fight, and they're tough
Hustler	Your money	Play them at pool or darts; they're good; they cheat at cards	Losing your wages; the hustler's friend is a pickpocket
Regular	Their stool	Say hello; respect the stool	Taking the stool starts a feud
Gambler	A game	Sit at poker; they lose big and borrow	They owe the cartel, and they'll point at you
Sailor	Another crew's night off	Rivalry: they'll race you at anything	A rival crew means a brawl at midnight
Oddball	Something strange	Talk to them; they have the best stories	Unknowable

Traits (three each)

Friendly, suspicious, lonely, loud, generous, broke, jealous, cowardly, violent, honest, liar, drunkard, teetotal, superstitious, romantic, grieving, hungry, flirty, married, in love with the bartender, afraid of the cook, hates sailors, loves sailors, owes money, carries a knife, carries a kidney cooler (hidden), has a tell, bad loser, good loser, cheat.

Traits set the dialogue options, the roll thresholds, the reaction to drinks bought, and the fight stats. A liar's stories don't match the fortune teller's reading; a superstitious patron will do anything a fortune says; a jealous patron fights whoever flirts with their partner.

Mood

Mood runs from Hostile to Delighted and moves with: drinks bought (+), being ignored (–, for Talkers), being flirted with (depends on type and your charisma), insults (––), being beaten at a game (–, bad losers ––), their drink being spilled (–), a round bought (+), the band (+ for most, – for Brooders), and the hour (everyone's mood loosens after 10 p.m. and sours after 1 a.m.). Mood decides what they'll do: Delighted patrons pay for your drinks, tell secrets, and take your side in fights; Hostile ones start them.

Conversation

Talking is a short mini-game: three to five exchanges with four options each (ask, agree, joke, challenge), each rolled against charisma and the patron's traits. Captions show what you said; at high drunk levels, what you said is not what you picked. Conversations give information (who's the thief, which hustler cheats, where the robbery's safe is), buffs (a laugh is +5 charisma for 5 minutes), items (a lucky coin, a key), and sometimes a fight.

The thirty regulars (the hand-written cast)

Name	Type	Traits	Secret
Old Marlow	Talker	lonely, honest, grieving	Was the Marguerite's captain; knows the safe's combination
Dottie Finch	Flirt	flirty, generous, liar	A kidney thief, and the best in town
The Reverend	Brooder	teetotal, violent, superstitious	Boxed professionally; a fortune can make him fight anyone
Sly Pennick	Hustler	cheat, good loser, has a tell	Scratches his ear before a bluff
Big Ruth	Regular	loud, friendly, in love with the bartender	Owens her stool; buys rounds for anyone who sits beside it, not on it
Little Ruth	Regular	suspicious, married, carries a knife	Big Ruth's wife; jealous of anyone who flirts with Big Ruth

Name	Type	Traits	Secret
Harrow	Gambler	broke, owes money, cowardly	Owes the cartel; will frame a player
Captain Vane	Sailor	loves sailors, loud, bad loser	A rival captain; a darts match with him is the night's main event on quiet nights
Mother Quill	Oddball	superstitious, honest, hungry	The fortune teller's mother; knows what the cards really mean
Tam the Cook	Staff	hates sailors, violent, honest	Will sell you the frying pan and the back-door key
Nellie Bright	Flirt	romantic, honest, lonely	A genuinely nice night out; the morning line is kind
Jasper Coil	Flirt	flirty, liar, carries a kidney cooler	A kidney thief who works with Dottie
The Twins	Talker	loud, friendly, drunkard	Finish each other's sentences; buying one a drink buys both
Deacon Pale	Brooder	grieving, honest, teetotal	Lost a brother at sea; the one patron who can calm the Reverend
Pip	Oddball	hungry, afraid of the cook, cowardly	A child-sized adult who sells scratch-offs out of a coat; lucky tickets
Mrs. Albright	Talker	married, jealous, suspicious	Her husband is at the bachelor party; tells you where it is
Cutter Jones	Sailor	violent, loves sailors, drunkard	Starts the midnight brawl if any rival crew is in
Lady Severine	Flirt	generous, liar, superstitious	Rich; going home with her is a mansion, a butler, and a dawn chase by her husband

Name	Type	Traits	Secret
Bosun Grieve	Regular	honest, good loser, broke	Teaches pool for a pint
The Widow Tusk	Oddball	superstitious, romantic, carries a knife	Her late husband haunts the snug (a sound-only ghost)
Finnegan	Gambler	cheat, loud, bad loser	Marks cards; catching him is a story
Sister Ash	Brooder	teetotal, honest, violent	A nun who drinks water and throws the hardest punch in the bar
Mr. Lemmon	Talker	lonely, generous, drunkard	Will pay your tab if you listen for ten minutes
Red Haddock	Hustler	cheat, has a tell, cowardly	Throws darts left-handed when nervous
Juno Marsh	Flirt	flirty, honest, in love with the bartender	Flirting back ends with her setting you up with someone else
The Lamplighter	Oddball	superstitious, lonely, honest	Only here between 7 and 8; knows the night's crowd curve
Bartholomew Crane	Gambler	owes money, liar, romantic	The cartel's informant; a decent poker player
Sweet Wren	Flirt	romantic, generous, afraid of the cook	The nicest person in the bar; going home with her is a cup of tea and a lecture
Boxer Mags	Brooder	violent, good loser, drunkard	Fights for fun, buys you a drink after
The Gull himself (the bartender)	Staff	honest, suspicious, in love with Big Ruth	See Money; keeps a shotgun under the counter and a grudge in the tab book

The generator's extras get a type, three random traits, and one of eight generic secrets (owes money, carries a knife, kidney thief at 3%, undercover police, cartel runner, married to someone here, lucky, cursed).

Flirting and going home

Flirting is a conversation with stakes: three rounds, a charisma roll against the patron's interest, and an offer at the end that you can take or walk away from. What happens after the door closes depends on who they were, and you usually don't know until the morning.

The flirt mini-game

1. **Open.** Choose a line (compliment, joke, buy a drink, dance invitation). Roll charisma + the line's fit against the patron's traits. A romantic patron wants a compliment; a flirty one wants a joke; a suspicious one wants a drink first; a loud one wants to dance.
2. **Build.** Two more exchanges with four options each. Each success raises **interest** by one; each failure drops it. Three successes make the offer; two failures end it. Drunk captions apply: at 60+ drunk, what you say is a surprise.
3. **The offer.** "Walk me home?" or "My place is upstairs." Take it and your night ends in a fade; decline and you keep a friend (+mood, they'll back you in a fight).
4. **Signals.** Each type has a tell that a sober player can read: a kidney thief glances at the toilets' window; a married patron turns a ring; a sincere one laughs at your worst joke. Absinthe or a fortune shows trait icons outright.

Interest is modified by the room: a packed bar after 10 p.m. lowers every patron's threshold by 1; a round bought raises it; a fight you won within sight raises it for violent and loud patrons and ruins it for the gentle ones.

Where going home ends up

Who	Odds (of the 30 regulars)	What the morning says
A sincere night	40%	You wake at their place with breakfast, +100 score, a kind line, and a new friend for the next night
A sweet nothing	15%	Tea, a lecture, a bus home at dawn; +50; Sweet Wren's specialty

Who	Odds (of the 30 regulars)	What the morning says
The rich one	5%	A mansion, a butler, a dawn chase by the husband; +100 and a headline
The married one	10%	Their spouse's shoe through the window at 4 a.m.; you keep the score, lose a shoe
A robbery	15%	You wake in the alley minus your money and your coat; the dog is wearing your hat
The kidney thieves	10%	A bathtub of ice, a note, a stitch; the drunk meter doubles from now on
The fortune teller	5% (she's the only one who asks you)	You wake with your fortune changed and a tarot card in your pocket that is a real item

For the generator's extras the odds are the same with the kidney at 3%. The twist: the kidney thieves are the best flirts in the bar. Dottie Finch and Jasper Coil succeed on offers more than anyone, and their lines are the funniest. The sober player sees the glance at the window; the drunk player sees the funniest person in the room.

Avoiding the bathtub

- Ask the bartender: for a drink he'll tell you who's "trouble" tonight (one true name, one false).
- The fortune teller's reading names "a smile with a cooler" if you're about to leave with one.
- Go home with a teammate watching: a player who follows within 30 s can interrupt a bad night at the door (a short brawl in the alley; the thieves run).
- Carry the dog. Nobody steals a kidney in front of a dog.

Group outcomes

Two players can leave with the Twins (one shared morning line, both score). A player who leaves with someone another player was flirting with starts a feud with that player (the morning headline mentions it, and the next night's bartender does too).

Fighting and weapons

Fights are cartoon brawls: punches, grabs, throws, and whatever's in reach. Nobody dies from a punch. Weapons escalate what a fight costs, and the bar, the police, and the cartel all notice.

The brawl system

- **HP** 100, scaled by toughness (so a wrecked player has 200 and takes half damage, and a sober one hits for less and feels all of it).
- **Moves:** jab (quick, 10), haymaker (slow, 25, a windup you can see), grab (hold 1.5 s, then throw into a table or over the bar), shove, block (halves the next hit), dodge (at low drunk only: above 60, dodging is falling over).
- **Drunk aiming.** Above 40, your swings drift by the same curve as darts; a haymaker at 80 drunk might hit the wrong person, which starts a second fight.
- **Environment.** Tables flip (cover and a thrown-through surface), chairs are thrown, the bar top is a stage, stairs are a fall. A patron thrown through a window is out for the night and the bartender adds the window to your tab.
- **Knockout.** At 0 HP you're on the floor for 30 s; a teammate can drag you to the toilets. Three knockouts in a night and the bartender bars you.
- **Crowds.** A fight pulls in anyone within 3 m with a violent trait and anyone Delighted with either side. On a packed night a one-on-one becomes a room in under a minute. Sister Ash ends fights by walking into them.

Who fights

Brooders antagonized past tolerance; Sailors of a rival crew at midnight; jealous partners; anyone whose drink you spilled twice; the biker gang if the piano is touched; the bartender if you go behind the counter; the cook if you enter the kitchen without buying food; a hustler you caught cheating (they swing first); and any patron a teammate has made Hostile and pointed at you.

Weapons

Weapon	How to get it	Damage	Consequence
Fists	—	10 / 25	None

Weapon	How to get it	Damage	Consequence
Beer bottle	Pick one up; smash it on the bar (a 1 s animation) to make it a broken bottle	15, or 30 broken with a bleed	A broken bottle makes the fight "armed": the bartender calls the police (a Police Inspection in 3 minutes)
Pool cue	Take it from the rack or from a player's hands	20; breaks after 3 hits into a jagged half (25)	One fewer cue for the rest of the night
Chair	Pick up	20, thrown 30	Furniture bill
Frying pan	Buy from the cook (20) or take it (the cook fights)	30, a stun on a haymaker	None, and the cook respects you
Dart	From the board	10, thrown 20	Pip faints
Golf club	From the yard	25	The yard's lights go off (the groundskeeper is upset)
The dog	Feed it three times	Bites for 15, holds	The dog is a friend for the night
Knife	From a knife-carrying patron you've beaten, or the kitchen	35, bleed	Armed fight: police; a stabbed patron goes to hospital and the night's headline is grim
The bartender's shotgun	Get behind the counter (vault when he's at the far end, or during an event) and take it from under the till	One shot; anyone hit is hospitalized; everyone else freezes	The bartender bars you for the night; the police arrive in 60 s; firing it ends the night for you unless the cartel is the target, in which case the bar buys you a drink

Taking the shotgun without firing it is a legitimate play: during a robbery or the cartel event, the player holding it ends the event with a shout and gets a headline. Firing it at the biker gang is the worst decision in the game and is scored accordingly.

After a fight

The loser is on the floor; the winner's charisma is +10 for 5 minutes with violent and loud patrons and -20 with everyone else; the damage goes on the tab of whoever started it (the bartender's judgment, which favors whoever he likes). A fight during a police inspection is an arrest. A fight you win while sober is the hardest story in the game.

Bar games

Eight games, all playable against players or patrons, all for money, all affected by the drunk meter in their own way. Each has a hustler who is better than you and a tell that gives them away.

Game	Where	Players	How it plays	What drink does	Stakes and stories
Darts	Games room	2-4	501 or Around the Clock; aim with a reticle that drifts, release on a timing bar	Reticle drift grows with the meter; at Merry it's steadier (the courage bonus)	5-50 per game; a 180 is a story; Captain Vane's match pays 100
Pool	Games room, two tables	2-4	8-ball; a cue line that wobbles, power on a bar, English on a small dial	Line wobble; above 60 the cue sometimes misses the cue ball entirely	10-100; Bosun Grieve teaches; Sly Pennick hustles (he misses the first game on purpose)
Mini golf	The yard, nine holes	1-6	A putting line and a power bar; holes have a windmill, a drain, a sleeping dog, a loop, and the ninth that drops into a fish tank	Line sway; rain makes the ball float on holes 4 and 7	Per-hole bets; a hole-in-one is a story; the yard closes at 2 a.m.
Slot machines	Games room, three	1 each	Pull; three reels of fish, anchors, gulls, and kidneys; three kidneys pays a kidney (the only other way to replace one)	Pulls get faster and less deliberate; a wrecked player pulls until broke	2 per pull; 50 / 200 / 1,000 for pairs / triples / the kidney line; the machines are slightly rigged in the house's favor and the bartender knows which one isn't

Game	Where	Players	How it plays	What drink does	Stakes and stories
Scratch-offs	Dispenser, or Pip's coat	1	Scratch three panels with the cursor	Scratching gets messy; a wrecked player scratches the table	5 each; 0 / 10 / 50 / 500; Pip's are luckier and one in fifty is a map to the safe
The fortune teller	The snug	1	Three cards drawn from a deck of 22 (Depth's tarot: the Diver, the Helm, the Kraken, the Drowned, the Lantern); she reads them as a true prediction about your night	Absinthe lets you see the trait icons she sees	10 per reading; readings are real: "a smile with a cooler" names a kidney thief, "iron at the door" means a police inspection within the hour; superstitious patrons do what their reading says
Poker	Card room	2-6	Texas hold'em with Flats' card physics; blinds rise each hour; patrons have tells (ear scratch, ring turn, a cough)	Reading tells needs charisma: above 60 drunk the tells are invisible; betting gets braver (the courage bonus is real, and expensive)	Buy-in 50; the pot can hold a kidney, the deed to a patron's boat, or the cartel's money
Bullshit	Card room	3-6	Shed cards face down by rank, claim the rank, call the rank, call the liar takes the pile	Drunk players' claim captions are honest at 80+ (you say "two kings... no, one king"), so a sober player at a drunk table is a wolf	20 buy-in, winner takes all; a liar's trait gives patrons a straight face; honest patrons can't lie and everyone knows

Cheating

Every game can be cheated (a marked card, a weighted dart, nudging the slot machine, moving your ball) by holding the cheat key during the action. Cheating succeeds on a charisma-plus-sobriety roll; a failure is caught by whoever's watching, which means a fight with a bad loser, the bartender's judgment, or the whole table turning on you. A caught cheat at poker is a story and a feud.

Side bets

Any player or patron can bet on any game in progress by walking up and talking to a player at the table. Side bets are the way a player with no money left stays in the night.

The band and the jukebox

Not games, but the dance floor has a rhythm mini-game (hit the beats) that gives +15 charisma for 5 minutes to anyone who finishes a song. Drunk players dance badly and are loved for it (+5 regardless).

Money and the bartender

Every player walks in with 200 in wages. Money buys drinks, games, bribes, and favors; it's also what the night takes from you. The scoreboard counts what you walk out with over what you walked in with, so a player who spends nothing and leaves at 8 p.m. scores zero on money and zero on everything else.

Where money goes and comes from

Out	In
Drinks (3–25, rising with the hour)	Winning games (5–100 per game, side bets, the poker pot)
Game buy-ins	Slots and scratch-offs (rarely)
Bribes: the bouncer (20), the police (50), the cartel (whatever they ask)	A patron paying your tab (Mr. Lemmon) or buying your drinks (Delighted patrons)
Damage on your tab (a chair 10, a window 50, the piano 300)	Finding money: the robbery's safe (500 split), a hustler's winnings taken back in a fight, the bachelor party's kitty
Fines (200), hospital (100), the kidney (not for sale)	Borrowing from Harrow (he borrows it from the cartel; see Events)

The tab

Drinks go on a tab, not paid per drink. The bartender closes tabs at last call and at the door. A player who leaves without paying is remembered (profile) and the bouncer bars them next night until they pay double. A tab can be paid by a friend, a Delighted patron, or by winning it back from the bartender at darts (he plays one game a night and is very good).

The bartender, the Gull

The bartender is the bar's referee: honest, suspicious, and in love with Big Ruth. He has a mood like everyone else, and it is the most important mood in the room.

- **Delighted:** cheaper drinks, warnings about trouble (who's a thief, when the police are coming), and he looks away when you take the shotgun.
- **Neutral:** the menu at list price.
- **Annoyed:** prices up 20%, cuts you off at 60 drunk, and tells the police which of you started it.
- **Hostile:** bars you. One more incident and you're on the pavement.

What moves him: paying as you go (+), rounds (+), breaking things (-), fighting (-), going behind the counter (--), flirting with Big Ruth (---), buying Big Ruth a drink for him to give her (+++), and the hour (he's tired by 1 a.m.).

He also sells: the cigar cabinet's key (a cigar is +5 charisma with Gamblers), a cab home (50, the only guaranteed safe exit after 1 a.m.), and, if Delighted, the name of the one slot machine that isn't rigged.

Debt

A player at zero can borrow 100 from Harrow at the poker table. Harrow borrows it from the cartel, which means that at the cartel event the player is on their list. Debt at the end of the night is -5 score per 10 unpaid and, with a profile, a visit next night.

Events and the crowd

Events walk in the front door. Two or three happen per night from the schedule below, rolled against the hour and the crowd, and each one changes what the bar is for an hour. They are the night's set pieces, and they're all survivable, profitable, and funny if you read them right.

Event	Hour	What arrives	What it does	How to play it	How it goes wrong
The bachelor party	8–11	Six men in matching shirts, a groom in a sash, a kitty of 300	They buy rounds for everyone (every player +20 drunk for free), challenge anyone at darts and golf, and get louder by the hour	Win their money at games; keep the groom out of trouble for a reward from the best man; the kitty can be stolen	They adopt a player as the groom's "new best friend" and won't let them leave; the groom flirts with Little Ruth's wife
The bachelorette party	9–12	Eight women in sashes, a bride with a veil, a list of dares	They take over the dance floor and the snug; dares involve the players (steal the bartender's hat, kiss the Reverend, win a scratch-off)	Complete dares for charisma and money; the bride tips 50 per dare; the fortune teller reads them all	A dare is "take the shotgun"; one of them is a kidney thief on her night off
The biker gang	10–1	Twelve bikers on a convoy that parks in the yard	They want the pool tables, the jukebox, and respect; they are, in fact, a book club, and will discuss the novel with anyone who asks	Ask about the book (+charisma, a free drink); beat their leader at pool for a jacket (a toughness item); never touch the piano, which is theirs	Touching the piano or their bikes is a 12-on-6 brawl; the police come for the brawl
The police inspection	Any hour; always after an armed fight	Two constables and an inspector	They check the room: anyone armed, anyone wrecked, anyone under the stairs; the bartender points at whoever he dislikes	Be sober, be unarmed, be sitting; hide in the toilets; bribe the constable (50); Sister Ash vouches for you if you've been good	Arrest: fine, night over, mugshot; a player caught with the shotgun is the headline

Event	Hour	What arrives	What it does	How to play it	How it goes wrong
The robbery	11-2	Three masked robbers through the kitchen; they want the till and the upstairs safe	They hold the room; patrons freeze; the bartender reaches for the shotgun	Give them your money (lose 50, keep the night), hide upstairs and watch the safe, take the shotgun first, or help them for a cut (a third of the safe, and a feud with the bar)	Fighting them sober is a story; fighting them wrecked is a hospital; the safe's combination is Old Marlow's
The cartel	12-2	A quiet man, two large men, a ledger	They collect: from Harrow, from Bartholomew, from anyone who borrowed, and from anyone the informant named; they run a high-stakes poker hand with a kidney in the pot	Pay, play poker for the pot, or point them at someone else; the quiet man respects a good bluff and pays double for one	Not paying is the alley and a missing kidney; the shotgun fired at them makes the bar yours for the night
The rival crew	9-12	Captain Vane's crew, 5-8 sailors	Rivalry at every game; Cutter Jones starts the midnight brawl	Beat them at darts and pool for their wages; or buy them a round and make it a party	The midnight brawl on a packed night is the biggest fight the game can produce
The lock-in	Random, 10%	The bartender locks the doors at 1 a.m. and the night goes to 4	No police, no events, double prices, everyone gets honest	A quiet night of poker and confessions	Nobody can leave; a player who needs to goes out the toilet window
The wake	7-10, 10%	Deacon Pale's family and a coffin on the bar	Everyone's mood is grieving; fights are impossible; rounds are expected	Buy a round, listen to Old Marlow, win the dead man's darts tournament in his honor	Flirting at a wake is -30 with everyone and the Reverend notices

Event	Hour	What arrives	What it does	How to play it	How it goes wrong
The band	8–12, 30%	A steampunk lounge trio on the stage	Dance floor opens; the rhythm mini-game pays charisma	Dance; request a song (10) for a mood swing in the room	The biker gang's leader sings; nobody is allowed to laugh
The goat	Any, 5%	A goat	It walks in	It's a goat	It eats the scratch-offs

Crowd dynamics

- The crowd curve (Dead, Normal, Packed, Random) sets the base numbers per hour; events add their own people; a fight or a police inspection sends a third of the patrons home for 20 minutes.
- Patrons arrive in groups (couples, trios, crews) and leave in the groups they came with or the pairs they made. A patron who went home with a player is gone for the night.
- Rain brings the yard inside; last call empties the games room first; the bartender's last call shout is the night's last timer.
- The room's **noise** (a value from the crowd, the jukebox, and fights) sets conversation difficulty: at peak noise you have to be close to talk, which is why the snug exists.

Multiplayer

One to six players share one bar, one clock, and one crowd. There are no teams by default: everyone's night is their own, scored on its own, but everything a player does happens in front of everyone else, which is the point.

What players can do to each other

- Buy each other drinks (and spike them: a Gull in a friend's pint when they're not looking is +35 to their meter and a story).
- Play each other at every game, bet on each other, and cheat each other.
- Flirt with the same patron (the loser gets a feud and a headline).
- Back each other in fights, or start them: a player can point a Hostile patron at another player with a line ("he said it").
- Carry a passed-out friend out, or leave them, or draw on their face (a cosmetic that persists to the morning screen).

- Interrupt a bad walk home (follow within 30 s).
- Pay a friend's tab, or run up a friend's tab by ordering in their name while the bartender is Delighted with them.
- Fight each other. Player-versus-player brawls are on by default (the host can turn them off), cost both players the bartender's mood, and are what the yard is for.

Modes

Mode	Rule
Night Off (default)	As designed; individual scores; the morning headline is about the group
The Crew	Co-op: one shared score and one shared tab; the night ends when any player is arrested or hospitalized; everyone's kidneys count
Last One Standing	The night ends when one player is left in the bar; the others have gone home, passed out, been thrown out, or been carried out, by any means; the last one wins
The Wager	Each player secretly bets at 7 p.m. on what their night will be (go home with someone, win 500, win a fight sober, survive the cartel); hitting it is +300; the bets are revealed at the morning
Rival Crews	3v3: two crews, shared crew scores, a darts and pool ladder, and the midnight brawl is scheduled
Sober Night	No drinks (the bartender's on strike); charisma only; the cartel still comes
Solo	One player, a Dead or Normal crowd, and the bartender as a narrator who comments on everything

Keeping six people busy

The bar has enough stations that six players never queue: two pool tables, four dart lanes on one board (alternating), six poker seats, six bullshit seats, nine golf holes, three slots, the snug, the dance floor, and thirty patrons. Events are built to split the room (the

robbery holds the bar while the safe is upstairs; the bikers take the yard while the police check the toilets).

Voice and text

Text chat, pings, and six emotes (toast, point, laugh, shrug, fists up, fall over). Voice is assumed to be external. A player's drunk level is visible to everyone as a sway and a flush, so nobody has to say it.

Dropped players

A disconnected player's character sits down at the bar and nurses a water (the meter drops); if they return within 5 minutes they pick up where they were; if not, their night ends as "walked home" with whatever they had.

Presentation and technology

Third-person 3D (over the shoulder, with a free orbit for the bar), because the joke is watching your own character stumble. It runs on Red Tide's inked low-poly renderer and rig system, Flats' card physics for the tables, and the shared arcade networking layer.

Look

- **Style.** Depth's inked low-poly: flat shading, screen-space ink outlines, Bayer stipple in the shadows, a warm gaslight palette (amber, oak, brass, bottle green, red velvet) against the blue dock outside the windows.
- **The crew.** Playable characters are the Nautilus crew's silhouettes (Diver, Whaler, Stowaway, Mechanic, Captain, Nurse) in shore clothes, with the arcade's skins. Each has a rig with Chains for coat hems, hair, and whatever they're carrying.
- **Patrons** are built from the same rig with a body-plan sheet of their own: 8 body shapes, 12 heads, 20 outfits, 6 hats, and a palette per type, so thirty regulars and a generated crowd never look the same twice but always look like the Gull's.
- **Drunkenness is animation.** Sway, lean, a wider stance, a slower blink, misjudged reaches (the hand overshoots the glass), a lurch when the camera turns, and at Wrecked a full stumble cycle. Camera lag and a mild double-image post-process above 60. The mirror in the toilets shows it to you.
- **The room reacts.** Props are physics objects (glasses, bottles, chairs, darts, balls); every fight makes a mess that stays.

- **Faces.** Patrons have a mood face (five states) and a flirt face; tells are small animation clips (the ear scratch, the ring turn, the glance at the window).

Dialogue

All dialogue is text with formant-synth gibberish voices (each patron a pitch and rhythm), captioned in the ink style. The conversation and flirt mini-games are a four-option wheel; drunk captions substitute the spoken line after the choice. Dialogue lines are data (`nightoff_dialogue.json`): about 40 lines per regular, 10 per generic patron, grouped by situation and trait.

Simulation

The bar is a small agent simulation: each patron has a schedule (arrive, drink, play, talk, leave), a mood, a target (a game, a person, a stool), and a memory of each player. About 40 agents at full rate; events script their arrivals and goals on top. The host runs it; clients receive agent positions, animation states, and mood faces.

Networking

Host-authoritative through the shared layer: player movement predicted locally; conversations, games, bets, and fights resolved on the host; dice rolls are host-side and logged for the morning screen's story generator. Bandwidth is small (a few dozen agents, no projectiles beyond darts and balls).

Save and profile

The arcade profile stores: nights played, headlines earned, kidneys lost and won, the bartender's memory of you, feuds and friends among the regulars, and cosmetics. Nothing in it changes a night's numbers except the hangover and the bartender's prices.

Sound design

The Gull is heard before it's seen: the clink of glasses, thirty gibberish voices at once, the jukebox, the rain. Everything is synthesized through Depth's cue registry. The sound's job is to make the room feel crowded or empty, to make drunkenness audible, and to give every event a tell you hear from the door.

The room

- **Crowd bed.** A murmur made of layered formant voices whose density follows the crowd count; it rises at peak and thins at 2 a.m. until individual conversations can be heard across the room.
- **Glass and wood.** Clinks, scrapes, a stool dragged, the till drawer, the tab book's pen.
- **The jukebox** plays six synthesized songs (a shanty, a waltz, a music-hall number, a torch song, a jig, and the sad one after midnight that the bar sings along to). Requests cost 10.
- **Rain** on the yard's string lights and the windows when it starts; the smokers coming in.
- **The dog** in the alley, and inside once it's yours.

Drunkenness

- Above 40 the mix low-passes slightly and the crowd murmur blurs; above 60 your own footsteps get heavier and a faint ringing sits under everything; above 80 the room lurches with the camera and the jukebox is the only clear sound; at a blackout, silence, then the morning birds.
- Hiccups, a stumble, a glass dropped; the toilet's tap as the sobering sound.

Voices

- Every patron has a formant voice: pitch, rhythm, and a laugh. The regulars' voices are distinct enough to recognize from across the bar (Big Ruth's laugh, the Reverend's growl, the Twins in unison).
- Players' crew voices from Red Tide's bark system, reused with new line sets: toasts, taunts across the pool table, the "I'm fine" at 80 drunk.

Games

Dart thud, the chalk, the cheer for a 180; pool's click and the thunk of a pocket; mini golf's windmill creak and the fish-tank splash on the ninth; slot reels and the three-kidney jackpot bell; scratch-off scratching; the fortune teller's cards and a chime per card; poker chips and the shuffle; bullshit's slap of a called pile.

Fights

Cartoon punches (a soft thud with a slide whistle at Wrecked), the bottle smash, the cue crack, a chair through a table, a window, the shotgun's single enormous boom and the silence after it.

Events (each heard before seen)

The bachelor party's cheer from the street; the bachelorette's whistles; the bikers' engines in the yard (and, a minute later, a polite discussion of chapter nine); the police's knock and the inspector's whistle; the robbery's kitchen door and a shout; the cartel's quiet (the murmur drops when they walk in); the rival crew's shanty; the lock-in's bolt; the wake's organ; the band tuning; the goat.

Music

The jukebox is the music. When it's silent, a low piano from the stage noodles by itself (the ghost of the Widow Tusk's husband, if you ask her). The morning screen plays a hungover waltz.

Build order, data, and open questions

Data files

File	Holds
<code>nightoff_patrons.json</code>	The 30 regulars and the generator's parts (types, traits, secrets, looks)
<code>nightoff_dialogue.json</code>	Conversation and flirt lines by situation and trait; drunk substitutions
<code>nightoff_drinks.json</code>	The menu, prices by hour, effects
<code>nightoff_games.json</code>	Each game's rules, drunk curves, hustler settings, payouts
<code>nightoff_events.json</code>	The eleven events: hours, arrivals, goals, outcomes
<code>nightoff_bar.json</code>	The rooms, props, weapons, and what breaks

File	Holds
<code>nightoff_scoring.json</code>	The morning screen's points, headlines, and story templates

Build order

Stage	Work	Gate
1	The bar as a 3D space, the crew characters, movement, the drunk meter and its animation, the bartender and the menu	One player can walk in, drink, stumble, and pass out
2	The patron simulation: schedules, moods, memory, the conversation mini-game, 10 regulars	A dead night is playable alone
3	Games: darts and pool first, then golf, slots, scratch-offs, the fortune teller	Every game beats a hustler and loses to one
4	Fights and weapons, the room's mess and damage, the tab	A brawl wrecks the games room and the bill is right
5	Flirting and the morning after: outcomes, the kidney, headlines and story templates	Someone loses a kidney and the headline is funny
6	Multiplayer through the shared layer: six players, modes, drop handling	Six players on LAN finish a night
7	Events, all eleven; the crowd curves; the rest of the regulars	A packed night with the bikers and the police
8	Poker and bullshit (Flats' card code), cheating, side bets, the cartel's kidney pot	The kidney comes back in a hand
9	Sound pass, profile persistence, the bartender's memory, internet play	Friends across the internet, three nights running

Tests

- `--night-sim <crowd> <players>` plays a bot night and reports: drinks per player, fights, kidneys lost, money in and out, which events fired, and the headline.
- `--patron-check` asserts every regular has a type, three traits, a secret, 40 lines, and a face.
- `--game-check <game>` plays a bot against each hustler at 0, 40, and 80 drunk and reports win rates (the targets: sober 55%, drunk 35%, wrecked 10% against a hustler).

Balance targets

- A careful player walks home with 300–500 and two kidneys about half the time.
- A reckless player loses a kidney about one night in five and gets arrested one in six.
- The average night has 2.4 events, 3 fights, 1.5 go-homes, and one headline nobody expected.

Open questions for the designer

- ☐ Decided: the kidney persists for one night; the Uber note delivers it the morning after that.
- ☐ Decided: player-versus-player fights are on by default, with a host toggle.
- ☐ Decided: two bars (the Sodden Gull and the Brass Monkey) with five traveling patrons, plus seasonal nights that players can attend or avoid.
- ☐ Decided: the cartel sells; see The cartel's wares. They remain quiet and funny, and nobody dies.

The second bar: the Brass Monkey

The lobby offers two bars. The Sodden Gull is the dockside pub; the Brass Monkey is the uptown place across the harbor: a former gentlemen's club gone to seed, with a card room that takes itself seriously, a rooftop instead of a yard, and a crowd that dresses better and fights dirtier. Most patrons belong to one bar; a few move between them, and what they remember travels with them.

Layout

Room	What's there	What's different from the Gull
The lobby and cloakroom	A doorman who judges coats, a velvet rope, the price board (everything 50% more)	You can be refused entry for being Wrecked or barred; a bribe (30) or a good coat (a skin) gets you in
The long bar	A mirrored bar with the Monkey's bartender, Celeste; cocktails instead of pints; the shotgun is a sword cane behind the bar	Cocktails are expensive and precise (see Drinks below); Celeste remembers everything and forgives nothing
The card room	Two poker tables (one high-stakes), a bullshit table, a croupier who deals, a cage that changes money	Cheating is harder (the croupier watches); the high-stakes table is where the cartel's banker sits
The library	Armchairs, a fire, a chessboard, a stuffed marlin	The quiet room: conversations only, no games, no fights (Celeste's rule: a fight in the library is an instant bar)
The billiards room	One carom table (no pockets) and a snooker table	Snooker instead of 8-ball: longer games, bigger money, a hustler who's a retired champion
The roof	A terrace with a putting green (three holes), a telescope, and a view of the Gull across the water	The golf is shorter and the fall is longer; the police come up the fire stairs
The cellar	Wine racks, a dumbwaiter, and the Monkey's safe	The robbery event's target here; the cartel does its business in the cellar, not a yard
The powder room	Marble, a chaise, a window to the fire escape	The kidney thieves' exit, as the toilets are at the Gull

The Monkey's drinks

Celeste serves cocktails: the Harbor Light (+18, +10% charisma for 3 minutes), the Sidecar (+20), the Marlin (+30, a snooker buff: cue wobble halved for one frame), the Widow's Kiss (+40, honest captions and a tell: you see every patron's trait icons for 2 minutes), and Champagne by the bottle (+25 and a round for the room, 60). Beer is available and Celeste says something about it.

The Monkey's cast (20 unique regulars)

Name	Type	Traits	Secret
Celeste (bartender)	Staff	honest, suspicious, teetotal	Keeps a ledger of every favor owed in the room; will trade a favor for a name
Lord Ashby	Gambler	generous, bad loser, owes money	Has lost his house twice at the high-stakes table and won it back once
Mrs. Vantage	Flirt	flirty, married, liar	Her husband is the doorman
The Doorman (Horace)	Staff	violent, honest, jealous	Mrs. Vantage's husband; the roof is his favorite place to settle things
Dr. Quince	Talker	lonely, honest, hungry	A surgeon; recognizes a stitch; can tell you which flirt has a cooler, for a drink
Madame Ostrova	Oddball	superstitious, generous, carries a knife	Runs a séance in the library at midnight; the stuffed marlin answers
Fitch	Hustler	cheat, has a tell, cowardly	The retired snooker champion; coughs before a safety shot
The Honourable Pim	Flirt	romantic, broke, honest	Rich in title, poor in fact; going home with him is a cold attic and a sincere breakfast
Sergeant Mallory	Brooder	violent, teetotal, honest	Off-duty police; a fight near him is an inspection

Name	Type	Traits	Secret
Lady Ophelia Crane	Flirt	flirty, generous, carries a kidney cooler	The Monkey's kidney thief; works alone; her tell is that she tips exactly double
Mr. Sable	Gambler	liar, in love with Celeste, owes money	The cartel's banker at the high-stakes table
The Marlin (stuffed)	Oddball	—	Speaks during séances only; its fortunes are the fortune teller's, relayed
Thistle	Regular	loud, friendly, drunkard	Owns the chair by the fire; the only loud person Celeste tolerates
Cordelia Fen	Talker	grieving, honest, romantic	A widow who comes to the roof to look at the Gull, where her husband drank
Boxer Mags (travels)	Brooder	violent, good loser, drunkard	Here on Fridays; fights on the roof
Captain Vane (travels)	Sailor	loves sailors, loud, bad loser	Drinks here when he's won; the Gull when he's lost
Sweet Wren (travels)	Flirt	romantic, generous, afraid of the cook	Visits her aunt (Cordelia); the same tea-and-lecture morning
Bartholomew Crane (travels)	Gambler	owes money, liar, romantic	The informant works both rooms
The Croupier (Anselm)	Staff	honest, suspicious, has a tell	Deals straight; touches his bow tie when a player is cheating
Juniper Vale	Oddball	superstitious, lonely, flirty	Reads the roof's telescope like a fortune; knows when the police are crossing the harbor

Patrons who travel

Five patrons move between the bars (Boxer Mags, Captain Vane, Sweet Wren, Bartholomew Crane, and Dottie Finch, who thieves wherever the coats are better). A traveler who's at the Monkey tonight isn't at the Gull, and their memory of a player is the same in both rooms. The ferry between the bars runs every game hour; a player can change bars mid-night (15 minutes of game time, the ferryman charges 10, and anything left on a tab follows you).

Which bar

The lobby picks the bar per night; the arcade profile tracks both bartenders' memories. The Gull is the louder, cheaper, fightier night; the Monkey is the richer, sneakier one, where the card room and the kidney thief are the dangers and the library is a refuge.

Seasonal nights

Some nights one of the two bars is hosting something. The lobby shows what's on where; players choose the bar with the event or the bar without it, so a group that wants a quiet poker night can take the other ferry. Seasonal nights change the crowd, the prices, the events that can roll, and the morning headline's flavor. They rotate on a real calendar (one is always available; which one depends on the date) and the host can force any of them.

Night	Where	What changes	Signature moment
The Harbor Festival	The Gull	Fireworks at midnight; stalls in the yard (a ring toss, a strongman bell, a fish-guessing jar); the crowd curve is Packed; every event's odds double	The fireworks are a 60 s window where every flirt succeeds one step easier and every fight is invisible to the police
The Storm	Either	The ferry stops; the power fails at a random hour (candles, no jukebox, no slots); the roof or the yard is closed; everyone who's in is in until it passes	A lock-in by weather; the bartender tells the story of the Marguerite in the dark

Night	Where	What changes	Signature moment
The Wedding	The Monkey	Lord Ashby's daughter marries a sailor; the card room is the reception; a free bar for an hour (every player +40 drunk if they stand near it); a toast mini-game (say something; the room scores it)	Objecting at the ceremony is a story; the groom is Cutter Jones
The Regatta	The Gull	Rival crews from three ports; the darts and pool ladder pays triple; the midnight brawl is a tournament with a referee (Sister Ash)	Winning the ladder sober is a headline that persists on the profile
New Year	Either	The clock runs to 4; a countdown at midnight; everyone kisses someone (a flirt roll for the whole room at once); the fortune teller reads the year	A player with no one to kiss kisses the goat
The Wake of the Year	The Gull	Deacon Pale's wake, bigger: the whole dock mourns; no fights possible; a confession round at the bar where every patron tells one secret	Every kidney thief is named, once, by someone, if you listen
Masquerade	The Monkey	Masks for everyone: patrons' names and traits are hidden; tells still work; the kidney thieves are three instead of one	Unmasking a thief before midnight earns their cooler (an item that stops the next theft)
The Cook's Birthday	The Gull	Tam cooks for free all night (sobering is free); the cook is Delighted and will fight anyone who doesn't eat	The only night the frying pan is given, not sold

Seasonal nights never remove the base game: the games, the patrons, and the morning after are all there. They add one layer and change the odds.

The cartel's wares

The cartel sells as well as collects. From the moment they arrive (and at the Monkey's cellar any time after 11), the quiet man's men will sell a player anything on the list for money or a favor. Every substance has an effect that is funny, useful, or disastrous, and most are two of those. They stack with drink.

Item	Price	Effect	The catch
Sea Salt	20	Sobers you 30 points over 2 minutes	Your hands shake for 5 minutes: darts, pool, and golf are hopeless
Lamp Oil	30	+30% charisma for 5 minutes; your captions become eloquent	Afterward, -30% for 5 minutes and you tell the truth to everyone (honest captions you didn't choose)
Barnacle	30	+50% toughness for 5 minutes, no pain (damage taken -30%)	You can't stop fighting: any patron who bumps you is a fight; the police count it as armed
Kelp Smoke	25	Everything is funny: +15 mood for every patron within 5 m while you laugh	You laugh during conversations, which fails every serious option; the Reverend hates it
Angler's Light	40	You see every patron's trait icons and the thieves glow	You also see things that aren't there (fake patrons who vanish when spoken to) and the fortune teller's cards change when you look at them
Deep Pressure	50	Time slows for you in games: aim, timing bars, and card tells are easy for 3 minutes	The drunk meter climbs 20 when it wears off and you miss the next 2 minutes of the night (a time skip; things happened)

Item	Price	Effect	The catch
The Siren	60	Everyone in the room is Delighted with you for 3 minutes; any flirt's offer comes early	Every flirt's offer is from whoever is closest, including the thieves, and your sober friends can't talk you out of it
The Cocktail	100	The quiet man mixes it himself; one of six outcomes, equal odds	1: the best night of your life (every stat maxed for 10 minutes, a guaranteed sincere go-home, +300). 2: you can fly (a double jump and a +40 toughness; you believe you can fly from the roof). 3: you become the bartender for 10 minutes (you serve, you take the tab, the shotgun is yours). 4: the goat and you understand each other (the goat follows you; it bites for you). 5: you wake up at the morning screen, immediately, with a headline you didn't earn and a kidney you still have. 6: you wake up at the morning screen, immediately, without one

Rules: one dose of each per night; nothing is sold to a player above 80 drunk (the quiet man has standards); a player seen buying by Sergeant Mallory or during a police inspection is searched; a dose a player didn't buy can be slipped into their drink by another player (the Siren and the Cocktail are the usual choices, and it's the game's dirtiest trick). The cartel never sells to the kidney thieves. They're competitors.

Skins and the token spin

A Night Off's arcade tokens buy skins, and nothing else. There are 50 skins: 10 that any player can save up for, and 40 that come only from the spin. Skins are cosmetic and visible to everyone, which in this game is the whole point.

Tokens

A night pays 10 tokens for playing, 1 per 50 score, 5 per headline earned for the first time, and 20 for a first on each seasonal night. A good night is 25–40 tokens.

The ten you save for

Skin	Cost	Look
Shore Leave	50	The crew's own shore clothes, pressed
The Sunday Best	80	A suit that doesn't fit, a hat that does
The Dockhand	80	Oilskins and a cap; the cook respects it
The Regular	100	Big Ruth's cardigan; her stool is briefly yours
The Croupier	120	Bow tie and sleeve garters; Anselm nods
The Fisherman	120	Waders and a hat of hooks; the dog loves it
The Bride	150	A veil and a sash; the bachelorette party adopts you
The Constable	150	A borrowed uniform; the police are confused for 10 seconds
The Gull	200	The bartender's apron and towel; Celeste is unimpressed
The Captain	250	Nemo's coat; Captain Vane challenges you on sight

The spin: 40 skins

One token, one spin, from a brass wheel in the cloakroom. A duplicate is a duplicate (the wheel laughs; nothing is refunded). Odds: Common 60% (15 skins, 4% each), Rare 25% (10 skins, 2.5% each), Super Rare 12% (10 skins, 1.2% each), Special 3% (5 skins, 0.6% each). Expected cost to own all 40 is about 290 spins, which is a long way to a Special and the reason to keep playing.

Tier	Skins
Common (15)	The Pint Glass (a glass costume, drunk level visible as a fill line), the Lobster Suit, the Sea Pig, the Barnacle (a man covered in them), the Cone Snail (a very large hat), the Wet Dog, the Fish Costume (from Depth's Island), the Sack (a potato sack with eyeholes), the Scarecrow, the Deckhand's Pajamas, the Lifeguard, the Diving Bell (you can't see out), the Gull Costume (the bird), the Sandwich Board ("EAT AT TAM'S"), the Beer Bottle
Rare (10)	The Goat (the goat), the Octopus (eight Chain arms that bump glasses), the Fortune Teller's Robes, the Biker's Jacket (the book club's), the Kidney (a large pink kidney with a face), the Mermaid Tail (you shuffle), the Ghost Sheet (the Drowned's), the Lantern Angler (your head is a lure), the Crab (sideways only), the Pirate (the platformer's)
Super Rare (10)	The Bathtub (you wear a bathtub of ice; a note is pinned to it), the Sandworm Puppet (a tube that eats your top half), the Marlin (the stuffed one, with the plaque), the Wedding Cake, the Pool Table (the Chains are the cues), the Slot Machine (your reels spin when you sway), the Cthulhu Mask (from Atlantis, glowing), the Great White (a shark suit with a flopping tail), the Uber Driver (Dottie's cap and a cooler), the Cartel's Quiet Man (a suit and a ledger; patrons go quiet when you walk in)
Special (5)	The Golden Kidney (an entire gold kidney; the thieves can't take what's on the outside), the Nautilus (the submarine, as a costume, with a periscope hat), the Sodden Gull Itself (a bar costume: a counter around your waist, a tiny bartender), the Matriarch (an orca suit with a pod of three balloon orcas on strings), the Headline (a newspaper costume whose front page reads your best headline so far)

Skins never change the numbers, with two exceptions that are jokes everyone sees coming: the Constable confuses the police for 10 seconds, and the Golden Kidney is still stealable (they take the costume).

The wheel's odds, the skin list, and the token values are data (`nightoff_skins.json`), so a season can add a tier or a skin without touching code.

Systems in depth

The numbers and rules Claude Code needs to build each system without guessing.

Conversation math

- A conversation is 3–5 exchanges. Each exchange presents four options (ask, agree, joke, challenge). Each option has a base difficulty (ask 40, agree 30, joke 50, challenge 60) adjusted by the patron's traits (a friendly patron: all -10; suspicious: ask +15; honest: agree -10, challenge -10; loud: joke -15; grieving: joke +30; liar: ask +10).
- Roll = $d100 + \text{charisma modifier (charisma\% - 100, so Merry is +10 and Wrecked is -80)}$ + mood modifier (Delighted +20, Annoyed -15, Hostile -40) + noise modifier (-10 at peak noise unless within 1 m).
- Success if roll $\geq$ difficulty. Three successes end the conversation well (information, a buff, an item, +mood); two failures end it badly (-mood, a fight if the patron is violent and the last option was a challenge).
- At drunk 60+, each option has a 25% chance to be replaced at the moment of speaking by a random option; at 80+, 50%, and the replacement is always the most insulting one available. The caption shows what came out.
- Listening (Talkers): a passive option that always succeeds and costs time; every 30 s of listening is +2 drunk (you keep sipping) and +1 patron mood.

Flirt math

- Interest starts at 0; the offer comes at 3; the flirt ends at -2. Each exchange: roll as above against the patron's **threshold** (romantic 45, flirty 35, lonely 40, suspicious 60, married 70, teetotal 65, in-love-with-someone-else 80), adjusted by the line's fit (the right opener -15, the wrong one +15) and the room (packed after 10 p.m. -5, a round bought -10, you won a fight in sight: violent/loud -15, others +20, you lost one: everyone +10).

- Dancing first: +15 charisma for 5 minutes. A cigar with a Gambler: +5. The Siren (cartel): every threshold -30 for 3 minutes.
- The offer's outcome is rolled from the patron's secret, not from the player: a kidney thief's offer always leads to the bathtub unless interrupted. A sober watcher within 30 s has a 100% interrupt; a merry one 75%; drunk 40%; hammered 10%.
- Tells play once per flirt, during the second exchange, as a 1.5 s animation; a sober player sees them clearly; above 40 drunk, the camera drifts at that moment 50% of the time.

Fight math

- $HP = 100 \times \text{toughness}$. Jab 10, haymaker 25, grab-and-throw 20 plus 10 if a table is in the way, weapon values as listed. Damage dealt $\times$ toughness; damage taken $\times (1 / \text{toughness})$ for the drunk damage reduction (so at 200% toughness you take half).
- Patron HP by type: Talker 60, Flirt 60, Regular 80, Gambler 70, Hustler 70, Sailor 120, Brooder 150, Oddball 50, Staff 200; violent trait +50; teetotal +20 (they're sober); drunkard -20 and +50% damage dealt (they're not).
- Haymaker windup is 0.6 s and can be dodged by a sober player; at 40+ dodging has a 30% chance to be a stumble into the punch.
- Crowd pull: every 10 s a fight runs, each violent patron within 3 m joins with probability 50%, each Delighted-with-a-side patron 30%, Sister Ash 100% to end it (she hits both).
- Weapon escalation: a broken bottle or a knife anywhere in the room sets the police timer (3 minutes) and the bartender's mood -20; the shotgun sets the timer to 60 s on being taken and ends the night on being fired, except at the robbers or the cartel.

Patron AI

- Each patron runs a schedule: arrive (hour from their row), a goal queue (drink, game, person, stool, leave), a mood, a tolerance (how many bothers before Hostile: 2 for Brooders, 6 for Talkers), and a memory table keyed by player (drinks bought, insults, games won and lost against them, fights, flirts) that sets their opening mood toward that player next time they meet.
- Goals are picked by type: Hustlers go to the games room when a player with money is there; Flirts drift toward the player with the highest charisma; Gamblers sit when four are at a table; Brooders find the emptiest seat; Regulars go to their stool and complain if it's taken.

- Patrons react to events by trait: cowardly ones leave when the police or the robbers arrive; violent ones join the brawl; superstitious ones do what the fortune teller last said; generous ones buy a round when the band plays.
- Leaving: at their leave hour, or when Hostile and nobody's fighting them, or when they've gone home with someone, or in pairs with whoever they flirted with successfully (patrons flirt with each other too; the room pairs off after midnight).

The fortune deck (22 cards)

The Diver, the Helm, the Periscope, the Lantern, the Kraken, the Drowned, the Siren, the Island, the Cave, the Weeds, the Sunken City, the Abyss, the Bottle, the Coin, the Knife, the Key, the Dog, the Goat, the Gull, the Stitch, the Bathtub, the Morning. A reading is three cards: who you'll meet, what you'll do, how it ends. The reading is generated from the night's actual seeded schedule (which events will fire, which thief is in, which patron will flirt with you), so it's true: the Stitch and the Bathtub together mean a thief will make an offer; the Key means the safe is open tonight; the Dog means feed it; the Morning drawn third means you'll walk home. The fortune teller reads a player once per night; a second reading is a lie she tells for fun.

The headline and story generator

The morning screen builds from a log of tagged moments (every go-home, kidney, fight, win, event, and cartel purchase, with who and when). Headlines are templates ranked by rarity: the rarest moment of the night leads (a sober shotgun on the cartel beats a lost kidney beats a hole-in-one beats a go-home). Templates are in `nightoff_scoring.json`, about 80 of them, with slots for names, numbers, and the goat. The morning line per player is chosen the same way from that player's log. Two players who did something together share a line.

The dog

The alley dog has a loyalty meter per player (fed once: follows for 5 minutes; twice: follows all night; three times: fights for you and sleeps outside your door, which stops the kidney thieves). It can be fed chips, stew, or a hustler's winnings (it eats money). Only one player can own it at a time; feeding it more than the current owner steals it, which is a feud. The dog's name is whatever the first player to feed it types.